the problem. The diplomatic challenges now are one of advancing new relationships while retaining earlier ones. And, within that overall mix, assigning the appropriate weightage to specific ones, so that India gets the optimal results in a world that is under transformation.

Analysing India's ties with the five permanent members of the UNSC is a good place to start an assessment of both its record and its prospects. Those with the US and China are addressed in further chapters.

The UK: A Contemporary Compact

More than any other relationship, India's ties with the UK carry the burden of a complex past. The scars of that period are both material and psychological. The challenge now is to make history work for the future of the relationship, where comforts and convergences overcome frictions and fissures.

Interestingly, it began as a symbiotic relationship in the immediate aftermath of India's independence. Current generations will probably be astonished at the extent of influence that the UK wielded in India for the next two decades. In fact, an Indian leadership anxious to stay out of the Cold War and keep the US at bay actually perceived the UK as its best foil. So much so that its radical segment even overcame initial reservations about joining the Commonwealth, believing that a British association would shield them from American pressure.

The recent success of the movie *RRR* is a reminder of how strongly feelings about the colonial era resonate with the Indian public even today. It is quite natural that there are sensitivities and wariness in the India–UK relationship that derive from this period. The partitioning of India may have left its own deep impact thereafter, but the subsequent India–Pakistan hyphenation clearly gave it even further life. Starting from 1947, when Pakistan attacked Jammu & Kashmir, the UK was perceived in New Delhi as being partial to Pakistan. This view, which grew further from the workings of the UNSC, was aggravated by the position that the UK took in the 1965 and 1971 conflicts. Britain's Cold War compulsions, the withdrawal from East of Suez and accession to the EU gradually eroded the proximity of the initial years. When it came to developments in Afghanistan after 2001, it did not escape New Delhi's notice that Great Britain was the strongest advocate of dealing with the military leadership in Rawalpindi.